CRA Rules & Complete Guide

RRSP and spousal RRSP rules for the 2026 tax year · the 3-year attribution rule · income splitting · federal and provincial rates

PART 1: RRSP + SPOUSAL RRSP CRA RULES (2026)

Rule	Key fact	What it means for you
2026 RRSP limit	$33,810	Your 2026 room is the lesser of 18% of your 2025 earned income or $33,810, plus unused room carried forward, minus any pension adjustment. Your Notice of Assessment or CRA My Account shows your exact number. (The 2027 limit is $35,390.)
60-day deadline	March 1, 2027	Contributions made from January 1 to March 1, 2027 can be deducted on your 2026 return. The FHSA has no such window; the RRSP does.
Spousal uses contributor's room	Your room only	A spousal RRSP contribution uses the CONTRIBUTOR's RRSP room. The annuitant's own room is not affected.
3-year attribution rule	Calendar years	If the annuitant withdraws in a year when the contributor made a spousal contribution that year or in either of the 2 previous calendar years, the withdrawal is taxed to the contributor, up to the amount of those contributions.
Any amount counts	Even $1	There is no minimum. Any spousal contribution in a year starts that year's window.
Calendar years, not 36 months	Dec 31 example	A contribution on December 31, 2026 covers 2026, 2027 and 2028. A withdrawal on or after January 1, 2029 is not attributed to that contribution.
RRIF minimum exception	Minimum is exempt	After the spousal RRSP becomes a spousal RRIF, only withdrawals ABOVE the annual minimum can be attributed.
Other exceptions	Separation, death, non-residency	Attribution does not apply if you are living separate and apart because of a marriage breakdown, if either spouse dies in the year, or if either spouse is a non-resident (some conditions apply).
Form T2205	When attribution applies	Form T2205 (Amounts from a Spousal or Common-law Partner RRSP, RRIF or SPP to Include in Income) works out how much each spouse reports.
Contributing after 71	Younger spouse	Your own RRSP must mature by the end of the year you turn 71, but you can keep contributing to a spousal RRSP until the end of the year your SPOUSE turns 71, as long as you still have room.
Over-contribution buffer	$2,000	You can be over your limit by up to $2,000 without penalty. Beyond that, the tax is 1% per month on the excess; file Form T1-OVP.
Line 20800 deduction	Contributor claims	Contributions to your own RRSP and to the spousal RRSP are both deducted on the CONTRIBUTOR's Line 20800, never on the annuitant's return.

Rule	Key fact	What it means for you
Unused room	Carries forward	Unused RRSP room carries forward indefinitely. Check CRA My Account or your Notice of Assessment each year.
Deduction carry-forward	No expiry	You don't have to deduct a contribution in the year you make it. You can carry the deduction forward to a higher-income year.
Pension income splitting	Age 65+	Separately from a spousal RRSP, once you are 65 you can elect to split up to 50% of eligible pension income, including RRIF payments, with your spouse (Form T1032). A spousal RRSP also helps before 65 and with RRSP withdrawals, which this election does not cover.

PART 2: THE 3-YEAR ATTRIBUTION RULE, STEP BY STEP

If the annuitant (the spouse who owns the spousal RRSP) withdraws, and the contributing spouse paid into ANY spousal RRSP for that annuitant in the withdrawal year or either of the two previous calendar years, CRA taxes the withdrawal to the contributor, up to the total contributed in those three years. Anything above that amount is taxed to the annuitant.

Attribution Tracker example (each row is one contribution year)

Year	Spousal contribution	Safe after	Status (as of 2026)	At risk	What to do
2023	$5,000	Jan 1, 2026	SAFE	$0	Contribution no longer in a 3-year window
2024	$8,000	Jan 1, 2027	AT RISK in 2026	$8,000	Withdrawals in 2026 can still be attributed
2025	$10,000	Jan 1, 2028	AT RISK	$10,000	Hold off until Jan 1, 2028
2026	$8,000	Jan 1, 2029	AT RISK	$8,000	Hold off until Jan 1, 2029
2027	$0	—	—	$0	No contribution, so no new window

In this example, a withdrawal in 2026 could be taxed to the contributor up to $26,000 (the 2024, 2025 and 2026 contributions). The Attribution Tracker does this math for you from the Transaction Log.

PART 3: WHAT INCOME SPLITTING CAN SAVE

When both spouses have similar retirement income, more of it is taxed in the lower brackets. The example below uses 2026 federal rates only, after the basic personal amount, to show the effect. Provincial tax adds further savings, and the Tax Dashboard in your tracker uses your real incomes and province.

Scenario	Spouse 1 income	Spouse 2 income	Federal tax (both)	Saving
Uneven: one large RRSP	$120,000	$20,000	~$19,150	—
Even: 50/50 split	$70,000	$70,000	~$16,490	~$2,670 / year

Illustration only, federal tax only. Real savings depend on your province, credits, other income and future tax changes. Talk to a tax professional about your situation.

PART 4: 2026 FEDERAL TAX BRACKETS AND YOUR DEDUCTION

Your Line 20800 deduction lowers your taxable income, so it is worth more in a higher bracket. You can carry it forward to a higher-income year.

Taxable income	Federal rate	Value of an $18,000 deduction	Strategy
$0 – $58,523	14%	$2,520	Claim now if you don't expect higher-income years
$58,523 – $117,045	20.5%	$3,690	Good value: claim now or carry forward
$117,045 – $181,440	26%	$4,680	Strong: worth carrying forward to this bracket
$181,440 – $258,482	29%*	$5,220	Very strong
Over $258,482	33%	$5,940	Highest value

Assumes the whole $18,000 falls in that bracket. *In this bracket the extra part of the basic personal amount is phased out, so the effective federal rate is about 29.3%. The 14% lowest rate applies for 2026 (it was cut from 15% in July 2025).

PART 5: TOP COMBINED RATES BY PROVINCE AND TERRITORY (2026)

Enter your 2-letter province code in Settings & Goals (B5). The Tax Dashboard switches to your combined federal + provincial rates instantly.

Province / territory	Code	Top combined rate on regular income
Alberta	AB	48.00%
British Columbia	BC	53.50%
Manitoba	MB	50.40%
New Brunswick	NB	52.50%
Newfoundland and Labrador	NL	54.80%
Nova Scotia	NS	54.00%
Northwest Territories	NT	47.05%

Province / territory	Code	Top combined rate on regular income
Nunavut	NU	44.50%
Ontario	ON	53.53%
Prince Edward Island	PE	53.00%
Quebec	QC	53.31%
Saskatchewan	SK	47.50%
Yukon	YT	48.00%

Top combined federal + provincial marginal rate on regular income, which applies at the highest income levels. Quebec residents file a separate provincial return and receive a federal abatement, which the combined rate already reflects.

PART 6: YEAR-END CHECKLIST AND ROLLOVER

When	Task
Year-end	Confirm you have not gone over your RRSP room (Room Remaining in Settings & Goals).
Year-end	Collect your RRSP contribution receipts from each financial institution.
Year-end	Contributions made January 1 – March 1, 2027 can go on your 2026 return. Log them in the Transaction Log.
Year-end	Claim both your own RRSP and spousal RRSP contributions on YOUR Line 20800.
Year-end	Check the Attribution Tracker and plan any spousal withdrawals for years marked SAFE.
Year-end	Review the income gap on the Tax Dashboard. A large gap may mean a bigger spousal contribution makes sense.
Rollover	File → Make a copy → rename to “RRSP + Spousal RRSP Tracker 2027 — [Your Names].”
Rollover	In Settings & Goals, change the Active Year (B4) to 2027.
Rollover	Update the contributor’s RRSP room and unused room (B10, B11) from your new Notice of Assessment or CRA My Account.
Rollover	Add 2027 transactions below your existing rows. Portfolio history and the Attribution Tracker carry forward on their own.

This guide is for general education and reflects CRA rules and rates for the 2026 tax year as published by the Canada Revenue Agency. Tax rules change every year. Talk to a CPA or tax professional before filing or making major RRSP or spousal RRSP decisions.

Sources: canada.ca (RRSP limits, spousal RRSP attribution rules, Form T2205, 2026 federal rates); KPMG, Combined top marginal tax rates for individuals, 2026.